BRIEFING

European Parliament

Understanding EU policies for people with disabilities

SUMMARY

The EU and its Member States have signed the UN Convention on the Rights of Persons with Disabilities and use its definition of disability as a common reference at EU level. There is no other harmonised definition of disability in the EU.

The introduction of the Global Activity Limitation Instrument indicator (GALI) in most of Eurostat's social and economic surveys offers the opportunity to have a clearer assessment of disability in the EU than before. It confirms that in 2024 the prevalence of disability was higher among female, older and less educated respondents.

The EU combats all forms of discrimination alongside and in support of its Member States. To improve the situation of people with disabilities, it has introduced a series of initiatives, programmes and strategies over a number of decades. The European Parliament has been highly active in the bid to end all forms of discrimination against people with disabilities, since the early 1980s.

In 1997, Article 13 of the Treaty establishing the European Community on the human right not to suffer discrimination on grounds, in particular, of disability, paved the way for a genuine disability policy. The first step in this regard was the adoption of a 2001-2006 action programme to combat discrimination. Later, the 2010-2020 European disability strategy sought to enable people with disabilities to exercise their rights and participate fully in society and the economy.

The 2021-2030 strategy, incorporating lessons learned from its predecessor, seeks to ensure that all persons with disabilities in the EU, regardless of their sex, racial or ethnic origin, religion or belief, age or sexual orientation: enjoy their human rights; have equal access to participation in society and the economy; can decide where, how and with whom they live; can move freely in the EU regardless of their support needs; and no longer experience discrimination.

This is a further update of a briefing, the first edition of which was published in November 2021.

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Disability in the European Union

Definition

Traditionally, there have been two main models of disability – a medical and a social one:

- the medical model focuses on the person's medical condition – illness or injury – which is the direct cause of their disability and may have an impact on their quality of life;
- the social model focuses on barriers created by society. Those may be physical or social restrictions preventing the development or use of the abilities – physical, social or professional – that each individual needs to thrive.

The two models view the interaction between the person's health condition and the environment in which they live differently. The medical one focuses on the person; the social one on the barriers created by the environment. In 2001, the World Health Organization published a new model: the international classification of functioning, disability and health (ICF). Based on three basic dimensions – body, activity and participation – the ICF model integrates the medical dimension of the health condition while at the same time referring to the context in which the individual lives and the society to which they belong. In line with the ICF model, in 2006 the United Nations (UN) adopted a very broad definition of disability in its Convention for the Rights of People with Disabilities (CRDP): 'Persons with disabilities include those who have long-term physical, mental, intellectual or sensory impairments which in interaction with various barriers may hinder their full and effective participation in society on an equal basis with others' (Article 1).

In the light of the difficulties encountered in adopting a common definition at EU level, when ratifying the UN CRDP, the EU recognised the UN's definition of disability provided in this convention. The Court of Justice of the EU has defined disability as an impairment that is 'long-term' and which, in the field of professional life, 'hinders an individual's access to, participation in, or advancement in employment' (Joined Cases C-335/11 and C-337/11, *Ring*; Case C-363/12, *Z*; Case C-354/13, *Kaltoft*). Under the duty of consistent interpretation, EU secondary legislation is interpreted in line with the UN CRPD.

Statistics

Data collection and data availability

As the concept of disability is so multidimensional, many difficulties arise when having to identify people with disabilities in surveys. At EU level, Eurostat is the main data provider through the European Statistical System (ESS) – the partnership between the Commission (here Eurostat), the national statistical institutes and other national authorities that are responsible in each Member State for the development, production and dissemination of European statistics. Currently, Eurostat carries out two broad population-based surveys, which include a limited number of questions relating to disability:

- the **European health interview survey** (EHIS), which provides data on the level of functioning and activity limitation among the population, and information on the population's health status, health determinants and healthcare use. Up to 2019, the survey was conducted every 5 years. As of 2019 it is conducted every 6 years. The fourth edition of the survey is taking place in 2025 across EU Member States;
- the **EU statistics on income and living conditions** (EU-SILC), which collects, once a year, data on long-standing activity limitation due to health problems (the Global Activity Limitation Instrument, GALI).[1]

Other specific survey modules collect data relating to disability, among them:

- the ad hoc module of the 2011 labour force survey, which examined the labour-market situation of 15-64 year-old people with disabilities living in private homes compared with (same age range) people without disabilities also living in private homes. In the survey, 'disabled people' are those who claim to have difficulties in performing some basic activities such as seeing, hearing, walking or remembering;
- the 2012-2013 European survey on health and social integration (EHSIS) collected data on the barriers faced by people with a health problem or having difficulties in performing certain basic activities in their daily life. This dedicated module was discontinued owing to quality concerns.

Although those surveys are a useful source of information, they are based on self-reported data and might be affected by respondents' subjective perception. Moreover, they do not gather information on people living in collective households or institutions (particularly elderly people and children with disabilities) or on children living in a private home (the EU-SILC survey starts from the age of 16).

As announced in its strategy for the rights of persons with disabilities 2021-2030 (see below), the European Commission introduced GALI, which is recognised as a good proxy measure for disability, to harmonise disability data collection in 2022. This disability variable is accompanied by detailed information on the type of disability, with the inclusion of a short set of questions[2] proposed by the UN Washington Group on Disability Statistics in a three-year EU-SILC module on health from 2022 on. As regards the collection of data about children with disabilities, an adapted GALI variable in the EU-SILC module on children was also created, to be conducted every 3 years.

Remaining barriers

Disability is not a marginal phenomenon in the EU. According to Eurostat, in 2024 almost one quarter of the EU-27 population aged 16 and over (23.9 %) reported some or severe long-standing limitations in their usual activities due to health: 17.2 % reported some long-standing limitations and 6.7 % reported severe long-standing limitations. Women were more likely than men to report long-standing limitations – either some, or severe – in all EU Member States (respectively 26.2 % and 21.5 %).

People in higher age groups tend to report some or severe long-standing limitations more than those in lower age groups, and the gender health gap increases with age. The prevalence of self-reported long-standing limitations is highest amongst people with a low income, and decreases progressively as income increases. In the EU-27, 33.0 % of the population in the first income quintile group (the 20 % of the population with the lowest income) reported long-standing limitations in 2024 compared with 15.1 % of the population in the fifth income quintile group (the 20 % of the population with the highest income). In the same way, the prevalence of self-reported long-standing limitations is lowest amongst people having completed tertiary education (15.7 %) compared with people having completed, at most, lower secondary education (32.9 %). The health gap between educational attainment levels is observable across all Member States. As a result, compared with people who do not have activity limitation (aged 16 and over), those who do face a higher risk of poverty or social exclusion (28.8 % versus 17.9 % in 2023).

People with disabilities still face significant barriers to accessing education, employment, healthcare, sport and culture, and to participating in the EU's political life. In 2024, 24.6 % of 18-24 year-olds with activity limitation within the EU were early leavers from education and training compared with 8.0 % of their peers without activity limitation. At EU level, the disability employment gap still stood at 24.0 % in 2024 (Eurostat). According to the Employment and social developments in Europe 2025 report, despite some progress, labour market participation remains a challenge for people with disabilities. Moreover, women with disabilities, young people with disabilities and people with high support needs are more likely to be discriminated against and excluded from the labour market.

According to a 2022 Eurobarometer survey on Sport and physical activity, having a disability or illness is the third most frequently mentioned reason for not practising sport more regularly (14 % of respondents). Those who left education by the age of 15 (26 %), older people (26 % of those aged 55 or over) and women (16 %) are more likely to say that they have an illness or disability.

Access to culture also remains difficult for persons with disabilities. A qualitative study, conducted across all Member States plus the United Kingdom, identifies a set of barriers that hinder the cultural participation of persons with disabilities, both as audiences and as creators. These barriers include lack of effective laws and policies, inadequate funding and support services, stereotypes, lack of accessibility, and a limited number of people with disabilities within cultural organisations.

People with disabilities still face additional barriers to exercising their voting rights. According to a 2024 FRA report, although many Member States have made progress by improving accessibility and removing some legal restrictions, obstacles remain in several areas. These include the persistence of legal capacity limitations in some EU countries, inaccessible voter registration and polling procedures, and inadequate provision of accessible information and communication. Many polling stations remain physically inaccessible, particularly for those with mobility or sensory impairments, while administrative and technical barriers – such as complex registration requirements or the need for medical certification – further restrict participation. Moreover, limited consultation with disabled people's organisations and insufficient training of election officials hinder effective inclusion.

Finally but importantly, in a 2023 Eurobarometer survey on Discrimination in the EU, almost half of respondents reported widespread discrimination in their country on the basis of disability (49 %).

Issues in the spotlight: Learning from crisis

Crises, including pandemics, conflicts, natural disasters and economic shocks, are associated with a range of factors that can exacerbate the difficulties faced by people with disabilities.

War on Ukraine

People with disabilities in Ukraine were already extremely vulnerable prior to the Russian invasion. During armed conflicts, the needs and vulnerabilities of people with disabilities are amplified, as is the risk of discrimination towards them. Ukraine is no exception: the mass displacement and chaos triggered by the conflict have raised serious concerns about violations of human rights inside and outside the country, in particular of those of vulnerable people such as women, children, LGBTI people, Roma and people with disabilities. In April 2022, the UN Committee on the Rights of Persons with Disabilities (UN CRPD) warned that 2.7 million persons with disabilities in Ukraine were at risk of being abandoned in their homes or in residential care, with 'no access to life-sustaining medications, oxygen supplies, food, water, sanitation, support for daily living and other basic facilities'. June 2022 estimates show that more than 143 000 people with disabilities have been displaced since the outbreak of the war.

In addition, the conflict has exposed people with disabilities to a disproportionate risk of death or injury and hampered their access to emergency information. People with disabilities often have no way to reach shelters or safe places, and because of mass displacement, they have been disconnected from their support networks. The UN report on the human rights situation in Ukraine, covering the period from 1 December 2024 to 31 May 2025, underscored that persons with disabilities encountered persistent obstacles in evacuating from areas of heightened insecurity and in securing adequate, affordable housing following displacement. The report further observed that this population remained at elevated risk of institutionalisation. A previous UN report, published in June 2022, stressed that Ukrainian children 'with visual, hearing, developmental or intellectual disabilities' are at higher risk of danger because 'they may not have learned about or understood what was happening' or were removed from or abandoned in their institutions without appropriate support.

Climate change

Europe is now facing war on the continent, a related cost of living crisis and the encroaching impacts of climate change all at once, and all linked with risks of increased difficulties for people with disabilities. In April 2020, the UN published an analytical study on the promotion and protection of the rights of persons with disabilities in the context of climate change. The study observed that 'persons with disabilities are disproportionately affected by climate change', as climate crisis is exacerbating existing health and health inequalities, revealing the lack of disability-inclusive procedures in the event of climate disasters, and reducing equal access to adequate housing.

Similarly, in 2021, during the 26th UN Climate Change Conference (COP 26), the International Disability Alliance published an advocacy paper for Disability Inclusive Climate Action and people with disabilities finally gained official status as a caucus recognised by the UN Secretariat. In 2022, COP27 was decisive for the inclusion of people with disabilities. The number of people with disabilities participating increased compared with earlier conferences, as did the number of events addressing disability organised by governments, UN agencies and other stakeholders. For the first time, the COP27 overarching decision as well as the action plan for climate empowerment included references to people with disabilities. In 2023, the COP 28 first global stocktake explicitly refers to persons with disabilities by acknowledging that Parties should respect, promote and consider their respective obligations on human rights, including the rights of persons with disabilities when taking action to address climate change. COP 29 saw modest progress on disability inclusion with new references to persons with disabilities in key climate finance and adaptation documents, and improved physical accessibility at the conference. However, formal recognition of persons with disabilities as a COP constituency, crucial for influencing negotiations, remains unresolved.

Cost-of-living crisis and energy poverty

The economic developments in the past legislative term were dominated by several consecutive shocks, from the pandemic to the energy crisis caused by Russia's war on Ukraine that, in turn, led to a sharp increase in inflation.

The financial situation of households has become a key area of concern since the beginning of the cost-of-living crisis in 2022. A growing share of people in the EU, and particularly those in vulnerable situations, face difficulties in making ends meet. This cost-of-living crisis may worsen health inequalities across the EU, particularly for people with disabilities, as the links between poverty and health problems suggest.

According to Eurostat, 13.2 % of persons with disabilities were unable to keep their home adequately warm compared with 8.0 % on average in 2024. This 'energy poverty' endured by persons with disabilities is the result of a combination of three main factors: low income, high expenditure on energy, and poor energy efficiency in buildings. Vulnerable people, such as people with disabilities affected by energy poverty, suffer from inadequate comfort and sanitary conditions, which may lead to ill health and higher mortality.

EU legal framework

Over time, the EU has paid increasingly close attention to the situation of people with disabilities. The question of what would be the right legal basis for introducing a genuine EU disability policy has also become increasingly important.

The rights of persons with disabilities have been enshrined in the EU Treaties since 1997. Article 19 of the Treaty on the Functioning of the European Union (ex-Article 13 of the Treaty establishing the European Community) stipulates that 'in defining and implementing its policies and activities, the Union shall aim to combat discrimination based on sex, racial or ethnic origin, religion or belief, disability, age or sexual orientation'. The Charter of Fundamental Rights of the European Union,

adopted in 2000, prohibits discrimination on the basis of disability (Article 21) and recognises the right of persons with disabilities to independence, social and occupational integration and participation in the life of the community (Article 26). The Treaty of Lisbon, which came into effect in 2009, attributes to the Charter the same legal value as the Treaties.

Adopted in 2006, the UN Convention on the Rights of Persons with Disabilities (CRPD) was the first international legally binding instrument to set minimum standards for the rights of persons with disabilities, and the first human rights convention to which the EU became a party. By ratifying the UN CRPD in December 2010, the EU associated itself with efforts agreed at international level to guarantee the fundamental rights of people with disabilities. By 2018, all EU Member States had also ratified the convention, committing, alongside the EU, to complying with the obligations under the convention and to setting up the mechanisms for its implementation and coordination.

European policies

First initiatives

The Commission has supported the development of a European disability policy through a succession of action programmes since 1974.[3] As an additional step, in May 2001 the European Commissioner for Employment and Social Affairs called on the European Council to dedicate the year 2003[4] to people with disabilities. Accordingly, in 2003, the Commission launched a European action plan on equal opportunities for people with disabilities for the 2003-2010 period. While significant steps were taken to improve the lives of people with disabilities in the EU during that period, some stakeholders questioned the adequacy of existing EU-level policy and regulatory frameworks to address the needs of people with disabilities properly.

Building on the results of the action plan, a European disability strategy 2010-2020 was adopted in November 2010, at a time when the process for the ratification by the EU of the UN CRPD was already under way (see above). The strategy was conceived as a policy framework through which the EU would deliver its commitments under the UN CRPD, in line with the respective competences provided for in the Treaties. It also complemented the EU 2020 strategy and the Charter of Fundamental Rights of the EU. It aimed to make it possible for people with disabilities to enjoy their rights in full and to participate in society and the economy on an equal level with others. To achieve these objectives, the strategy identified eight key areas of action: accessibility; participation; equality; employment; education and training; social protection; health; and external action. The strategy also included four instruments to implement the above objectives: awareness raising; financial support; statistics; and data collection and monitoring mechanisms as required by the UN CRPD. From 2010 to 2020, several initiatives were launched to implement the strategy.

- **European Day of Persons with Disabilities**. Each year (around 3 December), the Commission, together with the European Disability Forum, organises a conference to mark the European Day of Persons with Disabilities. The conference brings together decision-makers, people with and without disabilities, academic experts, the media and other stakeholders. They take part in the EU's efforts to highlight the issue of disability in accordance with the strategy.
- **European disability card**. In February 2016, a European disability card scheme was launched as a pilot project in eight Member States, to address the issue of lack of mutual recognition in disability status among Member States and to ensure equal access to benefits across borders for people with disabilities mainly in the areas of culture, leisure, sport and transport. According to the 2021 study assessing the implementation of the pilot action on the EU disability card and associated benefits, the initiative proved to be effective (see below).
- **Mobility of students with disabilities**. The Erasmus+ programme promotes the mobility of students with disabilities through youth mobility projects.

- **Accessibility**. After 4 years of discussions, the European Accessibility Act was adopted in 2019. Goods and services, including public services and assistive devices, must now be accessible to people with disabilities. Even if the provisions on the built environment are not binding, the Member States are encouraged to align their diverging requirements as much as possible. Persons with disabilities should encounter fewer obstacles when accessing transport, education or the labour market. The Web Accessibility Directive complements the European Accessibility Act by including provisions to make sure that people with disabilities have better access to public service websites and mobile apps. The inclusion of accessibility provisions in the Audiovisual Media Services Directive, the re-cast European Electronic Communications Code, the 'Marrakesh' Directive,[5] and the reaffirmation of mandatory accessibility requirements for projects financed through EU funds are also fostering accessibility in the EU.
- **Access City Awards**. To encourage cities to improve accessibility, the Commission has, for 16 years now, been granting an annual award to cities that invest in guaranteeing that their citizens have equal access to fundamental rights and, regardless of their age, mobility or ability, equal access to the resources these cities offer. In 2025, the Access City Award was won by Vienna in Austria (1st prize), Nuremberg in Germany (2nd prize), and Cartagena in Spain (3rd prize). The cities short-listed for the 2026 edition are: Piacenza (Italy), Rennes (France), Salzburg (Austria), Valencia (Spain) and Zaragoza (Spain).
- **Access to transport** for people with disabilities. Since the 2006 Regulation on the rights of disabled persons and persons with reduced mobility when travelling by air, the legislation on the rights of passengers with reduced mobility has evolved significantly with the revision of the 2014 Commission Regulation on the technical specifications for interoperability relating to accessibility of the Union's rail system, the adoption in 2010 of the Waterborne Passenger Rights Regulation and in 2011 of the Bus and Coach Passenger Rights Regulation, and the re-cast of the Rail Passengers' Rights Regulation in 2021.

The 2021-2030 strategy for the rights of persons with disabilities

In 2019, the European Commission launched an evaluation of the 2010-2020 European disability strategy to assess its implementation. The report mentions the inclusion of disability issues in European legislation and policy, notably in the areas of accessibility and passengers' rights, as some of the strategy's main achievements. The strategy also helped mainstream disability issues at EU institutional level through the European Pillar of Social Rights (Principles 3 and 17) and the European Semester. Nevertheless, the evaluation underlines many shortcomings, such as the lack of a comprehensive set of indicators, the absence of a framework to monitor the implementation of the strategy or the non-existence of binding links between the strategy and EU funding. On 3 March 2021, the Commission adopted its 2021-2030 strategy for the rights of persons with disabilities, which seeks to make progress on ensuring that all persons with disabilities in the EU, regardless of their sex, racial or ethnic origin, religion or belief, age or sexual orientation:

- enjoy their human rights;
- have equal opportunities and equal access to participate in society and the economy;
- are able to decide where, how and with whom they live;
- move freely in the EU regardless of their support needs;
- no longer experience discrimination.

Based on the lessons drawn from the previous strategy, the new one takes account of the diversity of disability comprising long-term physical, mental, intellectual or sensory impairments (in line with Article 1 of the UN CRPD), which are often invisible. Addressing the risks of multiple disadvantages

faced by women, children, older persons, refugees with disabilities and those with socioeconomic difficulties, the strategy promotes an intersectional perspective in line with the UN 2030 Agenda for Sustainable Development and sustainable development goals (SDGs). The strategy also announced several practical initiatives, which have been completed.

- On 15 December 2021, the European Commission launched its Disability Platform. The objective of the **platform** is to facilitate cooperation between the Commission and Member States on implementation of the new strategy. This includes the preparation of policy and legislative proposals relevant to disability, and representatives from Member States, non-governmental organisations and the European Commission working together to advance the implementation of the UN Convention on the Rights of Persons with Disabilities.
- A package of measures on the integration of people with disabilities into the **labour market** was published on 20 September 2022. This disability employment package helps Member States ensure that people with disabilities enjoy social inclusion and economic autonomy through their employment. On 8 December 2022, the Council of the European Union adopted conclusions on the inclusion of persons with disabilities in the labour market, urging Member States to implement the guidelines set out in the accompanying package. Building on this, the Council adopted further conclusions on 2 December 2024, aimed at strengthening the social integration of persons with disabilities. These later conclusions placed particular emphasis on improving employment opportunities and rehabilitation measures, including the provision of reasonable accommodation.
- 'AccessibleEU', a European resource centre created in 2022, provides a framework for cooperation between national authorities responsible for implementing **accessibility** standards and laws, with the aim of sharing best practice and improving the coherence and implementation of legislation across the EU.
- Following the 2016 pilot project mentioned above, the European Commission made a proposal for a European disability card and the European Parking Card for persons with disabilities on 6 September 2023. The Council reached an agreement with the European Parliament on 8 February 2024 for EU citizens and extended it to non-EU citizens in March 2024. The directives' main objective is to ensure equal access to special conditions and preferential treatment for persons with disabilities during short-term stays in other Member States. The directives i) introduce a standardised **European Disability Card** and improve the existing European Parking Card for persons with disabilities; ii) ensure that the European Disability Card is recognised as proof of disability, granting access to special conditions and preferential treatment offered by private operators or public authorities; ii) provide holders of the European Parking Card with equal access to designated reserved parking spaces as well as other parking conditions and facilities; iv) make information available in accessible formats about how to obtain these cards and about the special conditions and preferential treatment offered; v) and reduce administrative burdens for persons with disabilities, private operators and public authorities. Member States must apply these measures from 5 June 2028.
- With a view to ensuring that people with disabilities fully enjoy their rights as European citizens, the Commission published guidelines on their **participation** in the electoral process, as candidates and voters, on 6 December 2023.
- To support effective implementation of the existing rules on **air travel**, the European Commission published interpretative guidelines on Regulation 1107/2006 on the rights of persons with disabilities when travelling by air in October 2024.
- A **monitoring framework** was published on 25 May 2022, and a large set of **disability indicators** were developed as of the end of 2023.

- Guidance from November 2024 on **independent living** and inclusion in the community provides practical recommendations to Member States on the use of EU funding to accelerate the transition from institutional care to community-based services, and make independent living for persons with disabilities a reality. Building on this initiative, on 17 October 2025 the Council adopted conclusions on the social inclusion of persons with disabilities, with a particular emphasis on promoting independent living as a cornerstone of equal participation in society.
- Finally, at institutional level, the Commission is promising to renew its **human resources** strategy to promote diversity and the integration of people with disabilities. Likewise, the European Parliament is implementing the rights and principles highlighted in the UN CRPD, in the Charter of Fundamental Rights of the EU, in the Staff Regulations of EU Officials and in a set of internal high-level documents in such a way as to change the organisational culture and build an inclusive workplace for persons with disabilities.

Assessment

In a special report published in October 2023, the **European Court of Auditors** (ECA) assessed the 'practical impact of EU action' and concluded that it is 'limited'. According to the auditors, the key indicators for persons with disabilities have not improved and certain gaps have been identified in EU statistics in terms of frequency of coverage and level of detail. These differences in data may hinder the mutual recognition of the disability status in the EU. When assessing the Commission 2021-2030 disability strategy, the ECA concludes that, even if it sets out clear objectives, a number of key issues (e.g. the existence of 'invisible' disabilities, an inefficient link between EU funding and the strategy, a missing review of existing legislation, etc.) remain unresolved and the monitoring system in place does not provide information on how EU funding helps improve the lives of people with disabilities. On the basis of these conclusions, the Court of Auditors recommends that the Commission draw up a comparable statistical database, monitor and assess the relevant EU legislation to evaluate its compliance with the UN CRPD and work towards the establishment mutual recognition of disability status in the European Union.

In April 2025, the European Union underwent its **second review by the UN CRPD**. The Committee acknowledged progress in aligning EU legislation and policy with the Convention, including initiatives such as the European Disability Card and measures to improve digital accessibility. At the same time, the concluding observations highlighted areas where implementation remains incomplete, notably the slow pace of deinstitutionalisation, continuing barriers to labour market participation, limited attention to the rights of persons with psychosocial disabilities, and insufficient involvement of persons with disabilities in decision-making processes.

The Committee recommended that the EU intensify efforts to promote independent living, strengthen community-based support, ensure adequate resourcing of disability-related initiatives, and address intersectional forms of discrimination. Civil society organisations, through their shadow reports, broadly echoed these concerns, emphasising the need for more robust enforcement mechanisms and greater prioritisation of mental health within disability rights frameworks.

European Parliament

Since the start of the 1980s, Parliament has given priority to combating all forms of discrimination against people with disabilities. On the strength of the work done by the Disability Intergroup, Members of the European Parliament have adopted a number of decisions on the integration of people with disabilities and the acknowledgement and protection of their rights, calling on the Member States and the Commission to develop norms and regulations in the interest of people with disabilities. In 2023, the Employment and Social Affairs Committee (EMPL) organised the first European Parliament Disability Rights Week to highlight its commitment to persons with disabilities.

The third edition of the Parliament's Disability Rights Week takes place from 1-5 December 2025.

Disability Intergroup

The Disability Intergroup of the European Parliament (with the European Disability Forum acting as its secretariat) is an informal grouping of Members of the European Parliament who are interested in promoting disability-related policy. Established in 1980, it is one of the oldest and largest intergroups in the Parliament. The Disability Intergroup has been a key player in advocating and advancing the rights of persons with disabilities in the EU.

Since 2022, the intergroup has published a regular newsletter, highlighting the work of its members on disability. In its most recent edition (October 2025), the publication focused on the forthcoming phase of the disability strategy and on addressing the housing crisis.

Resolutions, recommendations and reports

In its 1996 resolution on the rights of disabled people, Parliament advocated the inclusion of disability non-discrimination clauses within the Treaty on European Union and the updating of legal frameworks such as the Employment Equality Directive to align with the UN CRPD. Parliament's 2021 resolution on inclusive labour markets reiterated the need for a non-discriminatory labour market, and highlighted inclusiveness deficits within EU institutions (resolution on protection of persons with disabilities).

Employment, social inclusion and economic participation is a consistent priority. Parliamentary initiatives, including the 2017 disability strategy implementation resolution, stress the mainstreaming of equality, and ensuring inclusive vocational education and fair pay. Resolutions in 2020 advocated a post-2020 EU disability strategy with ambitious targets, adequate funding and representation of people with disabilities to guarantee access to employment, healthcare, education and digital services, while promoting integration into the European Semester process.

Gender and intersectionality receive sustained focus, recognising that women and girls with disabilities face intersecting barriers such as limited access to healthcare, education, housing and high rates of violence. The 2013 resolution on women with disabilities and the 2011 resolution on the European disability strategy call for integrated gender perspectives and full involvement of persons with disabilities in decision-making.

Initiatives to address **practical barriers, accessibility and mobility policies** include Parliament's early promotion of a European parking card and the establishment of the AccessibleEU centre to support EU-wide accessibility standards (2022). In 2023, Parliament's resolution on the rights of autistic persons exemplifies tailored protections recognising the diverse needs within disability communities.

The issue of **updating and implementing EU policies** focuses on aligning EU disability policy fully with the UN CRPD. While the 2016 resolution on UN CRPD implementation set this direction, the 2017 strategy implementation resolution and the 2020 motion urged the mainstreaming of disability rights across all EU policies. The 27 November 2025 own-initiative resolution on an EU strategy for the rights of persons with disabilities post-2024, drafted by the Committee on Employment and Social Affairs (EMPL) further calls for a reinforced AccessibleEU centre, comprehensive mid-term evaluations, integration of disability rights in the post-2027 multiannual financial framework, and prioritised investment in inclusive education, employment, housing, and healthcare. It emphasises intersectional discrimination against women and girls with disabilities and the need to embed disability rights in EU external action and humanitarian aid, supported by strengthened governance.

Finally, special **responses to crises and their impact on vulnerable groups** took prominence during the COVID-19 pandemic. Parliament's resolution highlighted the disproportionate impact on persons with intellectual disabilities and their families, particularly on women carers, underscoring

the urgency of community-based services as alternatives to institutions to mitigate isolation and health risks.

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ENDNOTES

1 The 'GALI' question measures the proportion of people who claim to have been, 'for at least the past six months ... limited because of a health problem in activities people usually do'.

2 This set comprises questions on six core functional domains: seeing, hearing, walking, cognition, self-care, and communication.

3 The social action programme (1974); the Community Social Action Programme on the Social Integration of Handicapped People, 1983-88, (1981); HELIOS I (Second) Community Social Action Programme for Disabled People (1988); HELIOS II (Third) Community Action Programme to Assist Disabled People (1993).

4 The year 2003 was named 'European Year of People with Disabilities' (EYPD) to highlight and raise public awareness of the situation faced by such people. To this end, the EU set aside a budget of €12 million to stimulate initiatives and launched an action plan on Equal opportunities for people with disabilities: a European Action Plan (2004-2010).

5 This directive implements the Marrakesh Treaty to Facilitate Access to Published Works for Persons Who are Blind, Visually Impaired, or Otherwise Print-Disabled, which aims to facilitate access to print works in formats adapted for persons who are blind, visually impaired or otherwise print-disabled. The Marrakesh Treaty, to which the EU is party, is an international copyright treaty administered by the World Intellectual Property Organization (WIPO).

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